

TRIAL BY FIRE
The Vizag Steel Plant employees protesting against privatisation

BRS pitch was only to enable its chief K. Chandrashekar Rao (KCR)'s presence felt in Andhra Pradesh. How effective it will be remains a moot point as KCR's strong anti-Andhra stand during the Telangana agitation is well-known.

The ruling Yuvajana Sramika Rythu Congress (YSRC) government is determined that BRS stay out of the plant that is located in Andhra Pradesh. Industries minister Gudivada Amarnath says that according to the Union finance ministry's guidelines issued one and a half years ago, public sector enterprises of the Union and state governments are not eligible to participate in the bidding and the YSRC is totally against privatisation. YSRC general secretary and government advisor (public affairs) Sajjala Ramakrishna Reddy said the BRS is indulging in petty politics. Politics is indeed the BRS's motivation, says Hyderabad-based political commentator K. Nageshwar. "The strident anti-Modi campaign is the electoral plank of the BRS and opposing privatisation of the steel plant an emotive issue with the Telugus. Moreover, the YSRC, the Telugu Desam Party (TDP) and the Jana Sena have failed to take up the issue as it would be a direct confrontation with the Modi regime." The BRS, in his estimation, is therefore trying to seize upon the issue as a political opportunity.

Others are opposing privatisation on different grounds. They accuse the Union government of rejecting all alternatives that the unions, political parties and the Andhra Pradesh government have suggested against privatisation. The Jagan Mohan Reddy government has been batting for grant of captive mines and monetisation of surplus RINL lands to meet the present and future requirements of the steel plant. Employee unions say the company has nearly 24,000 acres, 'valued' at around Rs 1.5 lakh crore. Steel unions have another suggestion. "We have appealed to RINL to allow the Steel Authority of India Limited and the National Mineral Development Corporation also to file EoIs to ensure the company will remain in the public sector," says V. Srinivasa Rao, senior trade union leader and member of the All India Steel Consumer Council.

The Union government, however, reiterated its commitment to privatisation even as efforts are being made to improve RINL's performance and keep it going. BJP Rajya Sabha member G.V.L. Narasimha Rao believes that it will take another two years for the behemoth to turn the corner. Chairman and Managing Director Atul Bhat, however, while addressing the RINL collective on April 1, said the steel-maker could turn Profit After Tax-positive in the first quarter of FY24, even as he acknowledged that "FY 23 has been the most difficult year due to the multiple challenges". RINL employees, meanwhile, are bracing for the long haul in their protest against privatisation. ■

BJP IN MP

BETTING ON WELFARE BOARDS

By Rahul Noronha

With the assembly election just months away, the Shivraj Singh Chouhan-led Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) government in Madhya Pradesh has stepped up its efforts to woo smaller groups within reserved categories, much like the Congress regime in neighbouring Chhattisgarh, which too is scheduled to go to the polls in November this year.

On April 16, addressing a rally in Gwalior, Chouhan announced plans to set up welfare boards for sub-castes within the Scheduled Castes (SCs)—Koris and Jatavs. This comes after the state government on April 5 issued orders to set up four welfare boards, each dedicated to an Other Backward Class (OBC) group—Rajak (washermen), Telghani (Sahu-Rathore or Teli community), Vishwakarma (carpenters) and Swarnkaar (Soni or jewellers' community). The stated objective is the "promotion of employment and self-employment opportunities for the youth" of these communities. But, more importantly, the move will provide representation to these small socially and economically backward groups in the state's governance, as each board is to have a chairman from the same community who will be given cabinet minister rank.

A few of these OBC groups have a sizeable presence in parts of Chhattisgarh too. The state's Bhupesh Baghel-led Congress government had in fact set up the Telghani Board and Rajak Kalyan Board to ingratiate itself with the two groups back in 2021. Even the Opposition BJP in Chhattisgarh is trying to woo the Sahus; the ap-